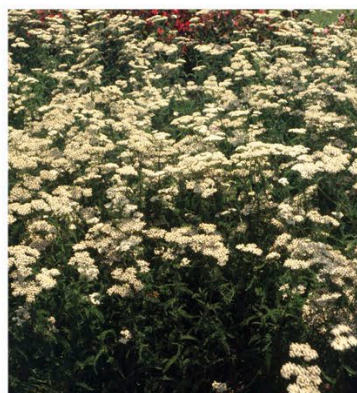


Achillea millefolium (Asteraceae)

Yarrow, Milfoil

Yarrow is a native European plant, with a long history as a wound healer. In classical times, it was known as *herba militaris*, being used to staunch war wounds. It has long been taken as a strengthening bitter tonic, and all kinds of bitter drinks have been made from it. Yarrow helps recovery from colds and flu and is beneficial for hay fever. It is also helpful for menstrual problems and circulatory disorders.



Yarrow was once known as “nosebleed” because its leaves were used to staunch blood.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Europe and western Asia, yarrow can be found growing wild in temperate regions throughout the world, in meadows and along roadsides. The herb spreads via its roots, and the aerial parts are picked in summer when in flower.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil with variable content (linalool, camphor, sabinene, azulene)
- Sesquiterpene lactones
- Flavonoids
- Alkaloids (achilleine)
- Triterpenes
- Phytosterols
- Tannins

Key Actions

- Antispasmodic
- Astringent
- Bitter tonic
- Increases sweating
- Lowers blood pressure
- Reduces fever
- Mild diuretic and urinary antiseptic

- Stops internal bleeding
- Promotes menstruation
- Anti-inflammatory

Research

Despite its many uses and similarity to German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), yarrow has been poorly researched. The herb and its volatile oil have been shown to be anti-inflammatory; the azulenes are also antiallergenic. The sesquiterpene lactones are bitter and have antitumor activity. Achilleine and the flavonoids help arrest internal and external bleeding; the flavonoids may be responsible for yarrow's antispasmodic action. Laboratory studies indicate that yarrow dilates blood vessels, thereby lowering blood pressure. It works, in part, like conventional medicines known as ACE inhibitors, which are commonly prescribed for high blood pressure.

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Healing wounds** Achilles reputedly used yarrow to heal wounds, hence its botanical name. It has been used for this purpose for centuries, and in Scotland a traditional wound ointment was made from yarrow.
- **Gynecological herb** Yarrow helps regulate the menstrual cycle, reduces heavy menstrual bleeding, and eases period pain.
- **Other uses** Combined with other herbs, yarrow helps colds and flu. Its bitter tonic properties make it useful for weak digestion and colic. It also helps hay fever, lowers high blood pressure, improves venous circulation, and tones varicose veins.



Yarrow

A creeping perennial, growing to 3 ft (1 m), with white flower heads and finely divided leaves.

Parts Used



Aerial parts contain flavonoids, which are thought to give yarrow its antispasmodic properties.

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** May cause allergic reaction in rare cases. Use the essential oil only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.



Remedy For colds, mix equal parts of yarrow, peppermint, and elderflower. Infuse 1 tsp with ¾ cup (150 ml) water for 10 minutes (see p. 291). Take 3 times a day.

Tincture (to make, p. 292). For indigestion, take 20 drops 3 times a day.



Essential oil extracted from the flowers is used by herbalists to treat congestion.

🍃 **Poultice** (to make, p. 295). Apply to grazes, cuts, and bruises.

Self-help Uses

- Cleansing wounds, p. 304.
- Colds & flu, p. 311.
- Digestive infections, p. 305.
- Fever, p. 311.
- Varicose veins, p. 302.